

About: topics and movement

Learner workbook

Use about for a topic and recognize its other meanings.

Understand the distinction

About often means on the subject of: talk about a film, think about a question, read about a place. It does not automatically make an action longer or more detailed.

Verb patterns differ. Discuss normally takes its topic directly: discuss the plan. Talk usually needs about before a topic. About can also mean approximately or around a place: about ten minutes; walk about the room.

Compare the patterns

TOPIC

We talked about the trip.

The trip is the subject of the conversation.

DIRECT OBJECT

We discussed the trip.

No about is needed in this pattern.

AROUND

She walked about the room.

About describes movement around a place.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: We discussed about the price.

- A. We discussed the price.
- B. We discussed on the price.
- C. We discussed to the price.

2. Does think about tell us how long someone thinks?

- A. Yes. It means thinking for a long time.
- B. Yes. It means thinking briefly.
- C. No. It introduces the topic.

3. What does about mean in about twenty people?

- A. Fewer than.
- B. Approximately.
- C. Exactly.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair correctly introduces the topic after talk and after discuss?

- A. We talked about the schedule. We discussed a possible change.
- B. We talked about the schedule. We discussed about a possible change.
- C. We talked about the schedule. We discussed to a possible change.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. We discussed the price.

Discuss takes a direct object for its topic.

2. C. No. It introduces the topic.

Duration needs additional context, such as for ten minutes.

3. B. Approximately.

This is a quantity meaning, not a topic.

4. A. We talked about the schedule. We discussed a possible change.

Talked about uses about; discussed takes its topic directly.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-07.html